



FOR MORE
STORIES



Dominant force: Phoebe Litchfield (above) finished the ODI series with 260 runs at 86.66, becoming the first woman to hit three 50-plus scores in a three-game ODI series both against and in India. Right: Off-spinner Shreyanka Patil provided a silver lining amidst the gloom for India.

EMMANUAL YOGINI & GETTY IMAGES

favour of its spin arsenal might have cost (for now) a talented player an opportunity to prove her worth against the best side in the world.

Age-old fault lines

"We've not played to our highest potential, especially in the fielding department. It's not up to the standard expected from the Indian women's team. I can assure you that we will work on it and come back stronger." This is what Jemimah Rodrigues had to say after the series defeat, which was sealed with a shocking 190-run mauling at the hands of the Aussies. Incidentally, head coach Amol Muzumdar, in one

of his earliest interactions with the press, cited fitness and fielding as priorities with the women's side. Add another 'F'-form to the mix.

Shafali Verma was dropped for the last two ODIs for her subpar run in the top order. However, does this conversation accommodate the stutters of captain Harmanpreet Kaur and Smriti Mandhana as well? Throughout this ODI series, the burden of constructing an innings or saving the chase came down to the middle and lower middle order.

Harmanpreet's scores of 9, 5, and 3 against Australia add to a few years of inconsistency with the bat. Mandhana, too, has been unable to convert her starts into big scores.

The team's decision to send Deepti Sharma over the explosive Pooja Vastrakar when the Indian chase in the second ODI needed to go at a brisk pace left fans and pundits flummoxed. Richa's elevation to number 3 is also puzzling, given that it not only puts her own aggressive game on the line but also makes a player like Jemimah, who is willing to become a floater in the batting order, collateral damage.

Communication is another issue. While the players and coach have visibly been working on encouraging honest conversations among the playing group, the selectors of the women's setup are insulated from queries and criticism. The committee, constituted by former India cricketers Neetu David, Renu Margrate, Arati Vaidya, Kalpana

